ARCANA (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Arcana is an **Intelligence** skill. It is used to **recall** details about **spells**, **magic items**, **occult symbols**, magical traditions, the planes of existence, and certain creatures (Aberrations, Constructs, Elementals, Fey, Monstrosities). The DM asks for a roll when the outcome is **uncertain** and **interesting**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. You take the **Study** action: an **Intelligence** (**Arcana**) check, consulting your memory, a book, or a clue.
2. The **DM sets the DC** using the official scale: 5, 10, 15, 20, 25, 30.
3. Two DCs are official: **DC 15** to identify an active spell, **DC 10 + level** to copy a scroll.
4. On an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect: no critical here.
5. An Arcana check often leads to another (**Tables** page).

Example: Mira (Intelligence +3, Proficiency +2) studies an unknown occult symbol (DC 15). She rolls 12 + 3 + 2 = 17: she recognizes an Elemental summoning seal.

⚠ Using another ability:

- The ability of a check is **decided by the situation**. Arcana can, for example, pair with **Wisdom** (sensing magic), **Dexterity** (drawing a symbol), or **Charisma** (lecturing scholars). Table rule
- The **Proficiency Bonus** applies when the skill **fits** and you are proficient.
- See the **Use cases** page.

⚠ Change from 2014

The **Study** action is new. It replaces the free choice of lore skill and ties Arcana to **creature types**. Identifying an active spell uses a **fixed DC 15**, with no Reaction.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

No official DC for most knowledge, and the line with **Religion** (divine magic, holy symbols) is debated. Fix: the **DM announces** the skill and the DC **before** the roll, and allows **one roll per subject**.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the **memory surfacing**: a grimoire passage, a rune glimpsed long ago, a whiff of ozone typical of a school of magic.

Step 1 – Decide whether a roll is needed:

A roll happens only if the knowledge is **uncertain** and **interesting**. A fact obvious to a mage is given with no roll.

Step 2 – Take the Study action:

You consult your memory, a book, or a clue: an **Intelligence (Arcana)** check. It is an **action**, which matters mostly in combat.

Step 3 – Set the DC: Table rule

The knowledge is...	DC
Very common	5
Common	10
Specialized	15
Rare	20
Very rare or secret	25
Legendary	30

The 5-to-30 scale is official; how knowledge is ranked (common, rare...) is a table suggestion.

Step 4 – Make the roll:

d20 + Intelligence modifier + **Proficiency Bonus** if you are proficient in Arcana. An ally can use the **Help** action to give you **Advantage**.

Step 5 – Resolve and chain:

- **Total ≥ DC**: you remember. The higher the total, the more you know. Table rule
- **Total < DC**: you recall nothing useful (or an error, per the table). Table rule
- A 20 or a 1 on the d20 **changes nothing** on an ability check.

Arcana uses in the 2024 rules:

Situation	Check and DC
Recall spells, magic items, occult symbols, magical traditions, planes of existence	Study: Intelligence (Arcana), DC set by the DM
Recall certain creatures (Aberrations, Constructs, Elementals, Fey, Monstrosities)	Study: Intelligence (Arcana), DC set by the DM
Identify an active non-instantaneous spell by its perceptible effects	Study: Intelligence (Arcana) **DC 15**
Copy a wizard spell from a scroll into a spellbook	Intelligence (Arcana) **DC 10 + the spell's level**

When one use case leads to another:

First check	Consequence	Next use case
Study: creature (Fey, Aberration…)	Success: you remember	Trait table (Creature Lore sheet)
Identify an active spell (DC 15)	Success: you know the spell	Choose the response: dispelling, retreat, countermeasure
Copy a scroll (DC 10 + level)	Success: spell copied	The spell joins the spellbook; scroll destroyed (Scroll sheet)
Study: magic item	Success: the item's legend or history	Identification of its real power (Magic Items sheet)
Detect Magic	You learn the school of magic	Study: Arcana to recall its effects

Chain example: Mira sees a lingering mist. An ally uses Help: Advantage. Study (Arcana) DC 15: she rolls 14 and 6, keeps 14: 14 + 3 + 2 = 19, success. It is an active Cloudkill spell: the group backs away.

Ability + skill combinations: Table rule

*The DM decides the ability by the situation and applies proficiency if it fits. These combinations are **exceptions announced before the roll**.*

Combination	Use in play
Wisdom (Arcana)	Sense a magical anomaly before any visible sign, by intuition.
Dexterity (Arcana)	Draw a circle or occult symbol precisely, without a single error.
Constitution (Arcana)	Sustain a ritual or magical vigil of several hours without faltering.
Charisma (Arcana)	Present arcane knowledge to scholars or a court to convince them.
Strength (Arcana)	Physically hold an unstable object charged with raw magic while studying it.

Neighboring skills:

Skill	Use in play
Intelligence (Religion)	Recognize divine magic, holy symbols, and Celestials, Fiends, Undead.
Intelligence (Investigation)	Decipher an encrypted message or a magical riddle from clues.

How to choose: Table rule

1. What does the task demand: **power, agility, endurance, mind, presence**? That gives the ability.
2. Which skill describes the **know-how**? Apply proficiency if it fits.
3. The DM **announces** the combination and the DC before the roll.

*Example: Brann (Dexterity +3, Arcana proficiency +2) draws a protective circle, DC 15. He rolls 9 + 3 + 2 = 14: failure, the lines are flawed. See also the combinations in the **Athletics** sheet.*

Common table questions.

Arcana or Religion?

Arcana: spells, magic items, occult symbols, planes, certain creatures. **Religion**: deities, rites, holy symbols, Celestials, Fiends, Undead. For divine magic, the DM decides by subject.

Does recalling something take an action?

Yes: **Study** is an action, which matters mostly in combat.

Can I identify an instantaneous spell?

No: only the identification of an **active spell** (DC 15) is provided. See the **Identifying a Spell** sheet.

Does Arcana identify a magic item?

Not its properties: that takes the **Identify** spell or a **Short Rest**. Arcana can recall its legend.

Is Arcana used to read a scroll?

No: reading a scroll takes a **spellcasting ability check**. Arcana is for **copying** a wizard spell (DC 10 + level).

Can I use Arcana with another ability?

Yes: the ability is decided by the situation. See the **Use cases** page. Table rule

Is a 20 an automatic success?

No: on an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect.

Can I retry Study on the same subject?

Table tip: **one roll per subject**, unless a new clue appears. Table rule

Which features help?

Expertise doubles the Proficiency Bonus. The Rogue can treat a 9 or lower as a 10. The **Help** action gives Advantage.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

Telling if an effect is magical

The game text says whether an effect is magical. Effects from spells and magic items always are.

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